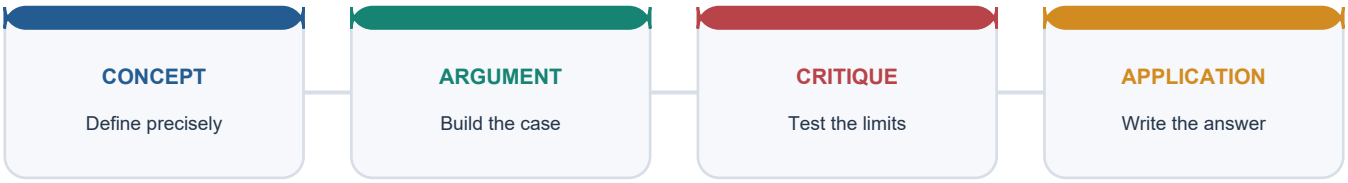
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

India on the Eve of the Medieval Age & Arab-Turkish Contacts - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

India on the Eve of the Medieval Age & Arab-Turkish Contacts - Solved Practice Workbook 4

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION 4

Workbook MCQ 01 4

Workbook MCQ 02 4

Workbook MCQ 03 5

Workbook MCQ 04 5

Workbook MCQ 05 5

Workbook MCQ 06 6

Workbook MCQ 07 6

Workbook MCQ 08 6

Workbook MCQ 09 7

Workbook MCQ 10 7

Workbook MCQ 11 7

Workbook MCQ 12 8

Workbook MCQ 13 8

Workbook MCQ 14 8

Workbook MCQ 15 9

Workbook MCQ 16 9

Workbook MCQ 17 9

Workbook MCQ 18 10

Workbook MCQ 19 10

Workbook MCQ 20 10

Workbook MCQ 21 11

Workbook MCQ 22 11

Workbook MCQ 23 11

Workbook MCQ 24 12

Workbook MCQ 25 12

Workbook MCQ 26 12

Workbook MCQ 27 13

Workbook MCQ 28 . . . 13
Workbook MCQ 29 . . . 13
Workbook MCQ 30 . . . 14
Workbook MCQ 31 . . . 14
Workbook MCQ 32 . . . 14
Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Medieval Topic 01 . . . 15
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE . . . 15
I.1 Audit method . . . 15
I.2 Directly owned Mains result . . . 16
I.3 Directly owned Prelims result . . . 16
I.4 Solved Prelims application PYQs - inferred answers . . . 16
M-1 · 2018 · GS-I · 10 marks · 150 words . . . 18
M-2 · 2020 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words . . . 18
M-3 · 2023 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words . . . 19
O-1 (10 marks · 150 words) . . . 20
O-3 (10 marks · 150 words) . . . 21
O-5 (15 marks · 250 words) . . . 21
O-7 (15 marks · 250 words) . . . 22
O-8 (20 marks · 300-350 words) . . . 23
O-10 (20 marks · 300-350 words) . . . 24

India on the Eve of the Medieval Age & Arab-Turkish Contacts - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 01

Which formulation most accurately distinguishes Arab maritime contact from later Turkish political expansion?

- A. The former was primarily a long-duration commercial-cultural process; the latter increasingly involved frontier bases and territorial warfare.
- B. The former eliminated Indian merchants before the latter began.
- C. The former began only after the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate.
- D. Both were identical movements led by the same institutions.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. The subject's master distinction is between overlapping but non-identical processes: centuries of commercial-cultural contact versus a later, increasingly territorial-military thrust.
- B. Incorrect. Indian merchants remained active around the Persian Gulf throughout; Arab trade did not displace them.
- C. Incorrect. Arab maritime activity and Sind contact long preceded 1206; the chronology is reversed.
- D. Incorrect. The two processes had different agents (merchants versus commanders/sultans), routes (sea versus frontier land) and effects (accommodation versus sovereignty change).

Trap: treating "foreign contact" as one undifferentiated story instead of separate commercial and military processes.

Workbook MCQ 02

Which political power is specifically associated in the source material with welcoming Arab traders and permitting mosques?

- A. Gahadavalas
- B. Rashtrakutas
- C. Tomaras
- D. Hindu Shahis

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. The Gahadavalas were a Gangetic-plain (Kannauj) dynasty, not the power associated with this Deccan/west-coast commercial accommodation.
- B. Correct. The Rashtrakutas are the power the source associates with welcoming Arab traders and permitting mosques - evidence of commercial accommodation, not Arab sovereignty over the Rashtrakuta state.
- C. Incorrect. The Tomaras held the Delhi region and are unrelated to this specific mosque-permission episode.
- D. Incorrect. The Hindu Shahis were a north-western frontier dynasty contesting the Ghaznavids, not a Deccan maritime power.

Trap: inferring political submission or conquest from evidence of religious/commercial accommodation.

Workbook MCQ 03

The most defensible description of the historical significance of the Arab conquest of Sind is:

- A. complete replacement of Indian Ocean merchants
- B. immediate establishment of the Delhi Sultanate
- C. a regional political foothold and conduit of knowledge exchange separated by centuries from the Sultanate
- D. origin of the Samanid state

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Indian and Arab merchants continued to coexist in Indian Ocean circuits after 712.
- B. Incorrect. The Delhi Sultanate formed roughly five centuries later, through an entirely different Ghurid-Turkish process.
- C. Correct. Sind gave the Arabs a bounded frontier province and a channel for translation and trade, without directly producing the later Sultanate.
- D. Incorrect. The Samanids were a separate Central Asian Iranian dynasty whose rise is unconnected to the Sind campaign's origin.

Trap: collapsing a bounded, centuries-removed regional episode into an all-India founding event.

Workbook MCQ 04

Turkish military elites entering the Indian frontier were:

- A. untouched by Iranian culture
- B. Persian-speaking but non-Islamic
- C. culturally identical to the Abbasid caliphs
- D. Islamised and substantially Persianised

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. They had already assimilated Iranian language and court culture after Abbasid fragmentation.
- B. Incorrect. They were both Islamised and Persianised; the two are not mutually exclusive.
- C. Incorrect. They were regional military commanders, not caliphal figures; "Persianate" describes a shared idiom, not identity with Baghdad.
- D. Correct. "Turkish", "Islamic" and "Persianate" describe different, intersecting dimensions of the same elite.

Trap: treating "Turkish" as a single undifferentiated ethnic or religious category rather than an intersecting military-cultural-religious formation.

Workbook MCQ 05

Who established himself as an independent ruler at Ghazni in 963?

- A. Alp-tigin
- B. Firdausi
- C. Muizzuddin Muhammad
- D. Jayapala

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Alp-tigin founded the Ghazni power centre in 963, opening the Ghaznavid sequence continued by Sabuktigin and Mahmud.
- B. Incorrect. Firdausi was the Persian poet who composed the Shahnameh, not a ruler of Ghazni.
- C. Incorrect. Muizzuddin Muhammad ibn Sam belongs to the later Ghurid phase (from 1173), two centuries after Alp-tigin.
- D. Incorrect. Jayapala was the Hindu Shahi ruler who resisted Ghaznavid expansion, not its founder.

Trap: confusing the Alp-tigin -> Sabuktigin -> Mahmud Ghaznavid sequence with the much later Ghurid sequence.

Workbook MCQ 06

The expression "outer bastions" in Satish Chandra is best read as:

- A. a fixed modern national border
- B. strategic depth formed by frontier zones such as Zabulistan and Afghanistan
- C. a religious boundary unaffected by roads
- D. evidence that Delhi's fall was immediate

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. It is a historical strategic-depth concept, not a claim about modern national boundaries.
- B. Correct. It names the frontier zones whose loss reduced India's strategic depth against Central Asian military states.
- C. Incorrect. The concept is about roads, bases and control, not religion.
- D. Incorrect. Frontier loss increased vulnerability gradually; it did not make conquest immediate or automatic.

Trap: reading a strategic-depth metaphor as either a literal modern border or proof that conquest became inevitable.

Workbook MCQ 07

Which statement best describes the Rajput political order?

- A. It lacked all agrarian and military resources.
- B. It was organised through the iqta system.
- C. It contained substantial regional powers whose rivalry complicated durable coordination.
- D. It maintained permanent unified command across north India.

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Rajput states possessed forts, agrarian revenue and armies; capacity was not absent.
- B. Incorrect. Iqta was a Turkish/Islamic revenue-service institution, not the organising principle of Rajput polities.
- C. Correct. The order combined real regional capacity with a persistent coordination problem among rival sovereign centres.
- D. Incorrect. Unified command was precisely what was difficult to sustain, not a permanent feature.

Trap: conflating "difficulty of coordination" with "absence of capacity".

Workbook MCQ 08

Which statement regarding iqta is least inaccurate?

- A. It abolished military-service obligations.
- B. It was necessarily hereditary and outside ruler control.
- C. It was unrestricted private ownership of cultivators.
- D. It was a revenue assignment linked to service and troop maintenance.

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. Iqta existed precisely to fund military-service obligations, not remove them.
- B. Incorrect. It was held at the ruler's pleasure and could be reassigned, unlike hereditary property.
- C. Incorrect. It assigned revenue collection rights, not unrestricted ownership over cultivators or land.
- D. Correct. Iqta was a ruler-controlled revenue assignment tied to maintaining troops and service.

Trap: mistaking a revocable service-linked revenue assignment for hereditary feudal landownership.

Workbook MCQ 09

Arrange the following in chronological order:

1. Alp-tigin establishes himself at Ghazni.
2. Muizzuddin takes Ghazni.
3. First Battle of Tarain.
4. Arab conquest of Sind.

- A. 4-1-2-3
- B. 4-2-1-3
- C. 1-4-2-3
- D. 1-2-4-3

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Sind, 711-12; Ghazni founded, 963; Muizzuddin takes Ghazni, 1173; First Tarain, 1191.
- B. Incorrect. It swaps the Alp-tigin (963) and Muizzuddin (1173) order.
- C. Incorrect. It places Alp-tigin's Ghazni before the Arab conquest of Sind, reversing the actual sequence by over two centuries.
- D. Incorrect. It places the Sind conquest after Ghazni's Turkish state formation, which is chronologically impossible.

Trap: assuming Ghazni's Turkish state formation preceded, rather than followed, the eighth-century Arab conquest of Sind.

Workbook MCQ 10

"Persianate" is best understood as:

- A. a synonym for Shia Islam
- B. a transregional sphere of Persian language, literature, court culture and administration
- C. proof of Iranian ethnicity
- D. a maritime trading corporation

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. It is a cultural-administrative category, not a doctrinal or sectarian one.
- B. Correct. It names the shared language, literary and administrative sphere that Turkish elites adopted.
- C. Incorrect. Persianisation was cultural and institutional, not a claim about biological or ethnic descent.
- D. Incorrect. It describes a court-and-administration formation, not a commercial or maritime institution.

Trap: equating a cultural-administrative sphere with a religious sect or an ethnic identity.

Workbook MCQ 11

Improved communications between Ghazni, Kabul and Jalalabad would most directly:

- A. create monsoon winds
- B. unify all Rajput states
- C. improve movement, supply, intelligence and reinforcement
- D. eliminate the need for revenue

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Monsoon winds are a maritime-trade factor, unrelated to overland frontier roads.
- B. Incorrect. Road improvement is a Ghaznavid logistics factor; it has no bearing on Rajput political unification.
- C. Correct. Roads converted frontier terrain into operational capacity: faster supply, intelligence and reinforcement.
- D. Incorrect. Better roads did not remove the fiscal basis (iqta/revenue) that funded troops and campaigns.

Trap: missing the specific logistics mechanism (mobility, supply, intelligence) and substituting an unrelated political or fiscal claim.

Workbook MCQ 12

A commercial diaspora is:

- A. a population cut off from all external ties
- B. an administration based only on Persian texts
- C. a conquering army settled on land grants
- D. a mobile merchant community retaining long-distance ties while creating local institutions

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. This is the opposite of a diaspora, which by definition retains external ties.
- B. Incorrect. This describes an administrative-textual formation, not a merchant community.
- C. Incorrect. This describes a military settlement (closer to iqta-holders), not commercial diaspora activity.
- D. Correct. Commercial diasporas kept long-distance trade ties while building local institutions such as mosques and residences.

Trap: confusing a settled merchant diaspora with a conquering or garrisoned military population.

Workbook MCQ 13

Which concept best captures the movement of Indian astronomy into Arabic learning?

- A. Translation ecosystem
- B. Territorial annexation
- C. Feudatory militarisation
- D. Biological diffusion

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Translation involves patrons, scholars, languages, selection and adaptation - an ecosystem, not a single event.
- B. Incorrect. Knowledge transfer through Sind and beyond was intellectual/commercial, not a territorial-conquest process.
- C. Incorrect. This is an unrelated military-institutional term with no bearing on scholarly transmission.
- D. Incorrect. "Biological diffusion" is a category error; the process concerned texts and ideas, not populations or genetics.

Trap: mistaking an intellectual transmission process (translation, patronage, scholarship) for a political or territorial one.

Workbook MCQ 14

Why is "political vacuum" an unsafe description of north India after Pratihara decline?

- A. The Pratiharas continued unchanged until 1526.
- B. Regional successor states possessed political, agrarian and military capacity.
- C. No feudatories existed.
- D. The Cholas ruled every part of north India.

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. This is factually false; Pratihara power declined well before 1526.
- B. Correct. Gahadavalas, Chauhans, Paramaras, Chalukyas, Chandellas and Tomars each retained real state capacity.
- C. Incorrect. Feudatories were a normal part of these regional states' structure.
- D. Incorrect. The Cholas were a southern, maritime power; they did not rule north India.

Trap: equating the decline of one dominant dynasty with the total disappearance of organised political capacity.

Workbook MCQ 15

What does the First Battle of Tarain, 1191, demonstrate most clearly for causal analysis?

- A. The Ghurids had no cavalry.
- B. Punjab returned permanently to the Hindu Shahis.
- C. Turkish political success was not inevitable.
- D. The Sultanate began in 1191.

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. The Ghurids fielded cavalry throughout; the battle does not show its absence.
- B. Incorrect. Punjab's status as a Ghaznavid/Ghurid forward base was not reversed by this battle.
- C. Correct. Prithviraj's 1191 victory is the key counter-evidence against treating Turkish success as predetermined.
- D. Incorrect. The Delhi Sultanate formed roughly fifteen years later, around 1206, not at Tarain I.

Trap: treating a single reverse or victory as proof of a predetermined outcome, or confusing Tarain I with the Sultanate's founding.

Workbook MCQ 16

Which is the strongest explanation of the political transition?

- A. religion alone
- B. weapon type alone
- C. courage alone
- D. interaction of frontier change, mobility, concentrated command, rivalry and contingent decisions

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. Religion alone cannot explain why Turkish states also lost battles to Rajput and other opponents.
- B. Incorrect. Weapon type ignores logistics, finance and command that made mobility effective.
- C. Incorrect. "Courage alone" is the bravery stereotype the source explicitly rejects.
- D. Correct. The balanced, multi-causal formula matches the source's structural explanation.

Trap: substituting any single monocausal factor (religion, technology or courage) for the required structural, multi-causal explanation.

Workbook MCQ 17

Consider the following statements:

1. Arab traders settled on the Malabar coast.
2. Indian merchants remained active around the Persian Gulf.
3. A port mosque necessarily proves foreign territorial sovereignty.

Which statements are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Both settlement and continuing Indian mercantile activity are source-supported facts.
- B. Incorrect. Statement 3 is false, so any option including it is wrong.
- C. Incorrect. Statement 3 is false, so this option is also wrong despite Statement 1 being correct.
- D. Incorrect. Including Statement 3 makes this option wrong even though 1 and 2 are true.

Trap: Statement 3 confuses community religious infrastructure with proof of foreign sovereignty over the settlement.

Workbook MCQ 18

Which distinction is most useful when analysing Rajput military resources?

- A. fort versus temple patronage
- B. aggregate resources versus resources concentrated under unified command
- C. Hindu versus Muslim courage
- D. cavalry versus all other arms

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. Fort-building and temple patronage are not the analytically decisive axis for this question.
- B. Correct. The key distinction is between resources that existed in aggregate and resources that could be pooled under one command.
- C. Incorrect. This reproduces the rejected bravery/religion stereotype rather than a structural distinction.
- D. Incorrect. Arms-type comparison does not capture the coordination problem that mattered most.

Trap: reducing a structural capacity-versus-coordination analysis to a religious-courage framing.

Workbook MCQ 19

Rajputisation is most closely associated with:

- A. disappearance of Brahmanical legitimation
- B. a single migration in 1192
- C. interaction among agrarian expansion, political power and status formation
- D. replacement of agriculture by pastoralism

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Brahmanical legitimation was not eliminated; it remained part of the process.
- B. Incorrect. Rajputisation was a longer social process, not one dated migration event.
- C. Correct. It captures the interaction of agrarian expansion, political power and evolving status claims.
- D. Incorrect. The process involved agrarian expansion, not the replacement of agriculture by pastoralism.

Trap: treating a long-run social-formation process as a single dated event.

Workbook MCQ 20

Which statement most accurately treats cavalry advantage?

- A. Horses automatically defeat elephants.
- B. India had no mounted forces.
- C. Cavalry mattered only because of ethnicity.
- D. Mobility became decisive when integrated with command, remounts, intelligence and tactics.

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. Outcomes depended on organisation and tactics, not an automatic animal-versus-animal hierarchy.
- B. Incorrect. This is factually false; Indian armies fielded cavalry.
- C. Incorrect. Ethnicity is not the operative variable; organisation and logistics are.
- D. Correct. Mobility was decisive only when combined with command, remounts, intelligence and tactics.

Trap: attributing a battlefield outcome to a single technology or ethnic factor instead of an organisational system.

Workbook MCQ 21

The Gahadavalas are associated principally with:

- A. Kannauj
- B. Malwa
- C. Ghazni
- D. Gujarat

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Kannauj was the Gahadavala power base on the Gangetic plain.
- B. Incorrect. Malwa is associated with the Paramaras, a separate dynasty.
- C. Incorrect. Ghazni is the Turkish/Ghaznavid frontier base, unconnected to the Gahadavalas.
- D. Incorrect. Gujarat is associated with the Chaulukyas/Chalukyas, not the Gahadavalas.

Trap: confusing regional dynasty-territory pairings across distant zones of the subcontinent.

Workbook MCQ 22

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Tomaras - Ghazni
- B. Chauhans - Ajmer
- C. Hindu Shahis - Chola maritime empire
- D. Paramaras - Malabar merchant settlement

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. The Tomaras held the Delhi region, not Ghazni.
- B. Correct. Ajmer was a principal Chauhan (Chahamana) base under Prithviraj and his line.
- C. Incorrect. The Hindu Shahis were a north-western frontier power; the Chola maritime empire was an unrelated southern polity.
- D. Incorrect. The Paramaras were centred on Malwa, not the Malabar merchant settlements.

Trap: mixing up regional-dynasty geography across distant and unrelated zones of the subcontinent.

Workbook MCQ 23

An excavated port and a named textual port should be identified with confidence only when:

- A. a popular tradition exists
- B. one imported object is found
- C. chronology, geography, stratigraphy and other evidence converge
- D. the modern names sound similar

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Popular tradition alone is not independent evidence of identification.
- B. Incorrect. A single artefact cannot establish an identification by itself.
- C. Correct. Convergent chronology, geography, stratigraphy and inscriptional evidence together justify confident identification (as debated for Banbhore/Debal).
- D. Incorrect. Name similarity alone is weak, uncorroborated evidence.

Trap: accepting a single weak strand of evidence (legend, one artefact or name similarity) as sufficient for archaeological identification.

Workbook MCQ 24

Why can the eighth-century Sind conquest not explain twelfth-century Ghurid expansion by itself?

- A. Ghazni had already fallen to Delhi.
- B. Sind had no trade.
- C. The Ghurids were Arab merchants.
- D. centuries, different actors and transformed West/Central Asian institutions intervened

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. This reverses the actual sequence; Ghazni's Turkish rulers long predate any Delhi Sultanate takeover of Ghazni.
- B. Incorrect. Sind was in fact a commercial and knowledge conduit, not a trade-free zone.
- C. Incorrect. The Ghurids were Persianate Turkish/Iranian military rulers, not Arab merchants.
- D. Correct. Centuries of change, new actors and transformed Abbasid-successor institutions separate the two events.

Trap: assuming a single distant eighth-century event mechanically and directly produced a twelfth-century political outcome.

Workbook MCQ 25

The International Spice Routes Conference of January 2026 is safest used in an answer as:

- A. a current example of maritime heritage, cultural corridors and heritage tourism
- B. an official archaeological report on medieval chronology
- C. proof that Arab traders ruled Kerala
- D. proof of the exact location of every ancient port

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. It is a contemporary relevance anchor for maritime heritage and cultural corridors, not primary historical evidence.
- B. Incorrect. It is a heritage/tourism event, not an archaeological chronology report.
- C. Incorrect. Commercial settlement is not the same as political rule; no such conclusion follows.
- D. Incorrect. A 2026 conference cannot establish the exact location of ancient ports.

Trap: using a current-affairs anchor as if it were primary historical or archaeological proof.

Workbook MCQ 26

Gyan Bharatam's digitisation programme can improve medieval research primarily by:

- A. proving every manuscript's claim
- B. expanding preservation, cataloguing and research access
- C. making later copies contemporary eyewitnesses
- D. removing the need for palaeography

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. Digitisation improves access, not the truth-value of a manuscript's claims.
- B. Correct. It expands preservation, cataloguing and access for researchers.
- C. Incorrect. Digitising a later copy does not make it a contemporary eyewitness account.
- D. Incorrect. Palaeography and textual criticism remain necessary regardless of digitisation.

Trap: confusing improved access to a source with automatic verification of its factual reliability.

Workbook MCQ 27

Which method is strongest for using a Persian court chronicle?

- A. reject it because it is elite
- B. accept its royal claims literally
- C. identify genre and patronage, then co-relate it with other evidence
- D. treat silence as proof of absence

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. Outright rejection discards genuinely useful evidence.
- B. Incorrect. Literal acceptance ignores court patronage and idealisation.
- C. Correct. Identifying genre and patronage, then corroborating with other evidence, is the source-critical method used throughout this topic.
- D. Incorrect. A chronicle's silence on a topic does not prove that topic did not exist.

Trap: swinging between naive acceptance and blanket rejection instead of applying genre-aware corroboration.

Workbook MCQ 28

Which statement best distinguishes a raid from sustained expansion?

- A. A raid always changes sovereignty.
- B. Expansion never seeks revenue.
- C. A raid never uses cavalry.
- D. sustained expansion requires bases, garrisons, information and recurring revenue

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. A raid (such as Mahmud's expeditions) need not change sovereignty at all.
- B. Incorrect. Sustained expansion is precisely organised around recurring revenue.
- C. Incorrect. Both raids and sustained campaigns could use cavalry.
- D. Correct. Bases, garrisons, information and recurring revenue mark the shift from raid to durable expansion.

Trap: collapsing "raid/plunder" and "conquest/annexation" into a single undifferentiated category.

Workbook MCQ 29

Which proposition best reflects the relationship between geography and conquest?

- A. Geography creates opportunities whose use depends on logistics and institutions.
- B. Frontier states cannot resist external pressure.
- C. A mountain pass automatically determines political control.
- D. Roads are irrelevant to cavalry.

Answer: A.

- A. Correct. Geography enabled but did not determine outcomes; logistics and institutions converted opportunity into power.
- B. Incorrect. Frontier states such as the Hindu Shahis resisted for an extended period.
- C. Incorrect. This is geographical determinism, which the topic explicitly rejects.
- D. Incorrect. Roads were central to cavalry mobility, supply and reinforcement.

Trap: substituting geographical determinism for the required "enabling condition, not sufficient cause" analysis.

Workbook MCQ 30

Why is "the Turks came only as destroyers" analytically inadequate?

- A. They rejected territorial rule.
- B. They also carried Persianate administrative, literary and political institutions.
- C. No conflict occurred.
- D. They were all merchants.

Answer: B.

- A. Incorrect. This is factually false; territorial rule and revenue claims were central to the later transition.
- B. Correct. Turkish elites also carried Persianate courtly, administrative and literary institutions, not destruction alone.
- C. Incorrect. Conflict clearly occurred, including battles and resistance.
- D. Incorrect. They were commanders and sultans operating military-fiscal states, not primarily merchants.

Trap: reducing a complex political-institutional transition to a single destroyer/plunder narrative.

Workbook MCQ 31

Which framework produces the strongest causal answer?

- A. one decisive technology
- B. hero versus villain
- C. structural condition + institutional mechanism + contingent trigger
- D. civilisation versus civilisation

Answer: C.

- A. Incorrect. A single-technology explanation cannot account for reverses such as Tarain I or Gujarat 1178-79.
- B. Incorrect. A moralised hero/villain frame is not a causal-historical explanation.
- C. Correct. The condition-mechanism-trigger structure integrates structure, institutions and contingency.
- D. Incorrect. A civilisation-versus-civilisation frame is the communal narrative the topic explicitly rejects.

Trap: substituting a moralised or civilisational-clash frame for the required structural, multi-causal analysis.

Workbook MCQ 32

The best final judgement on the initial Turkish breakthrough is:

- A. unrelated to frontier change
- B. predetermined by the conquest of Sind
- C. proof of universal Rajput military inferiority
- D. made more probable by structural shifts but realised through contingent political and military choices

Answer: D.

- A. Incorrect. Frontier change (Hindu Shahi losses, Ghaznavid roads, Punjab base) was directly relevant.
- B. Incorrect. The Sind conquest, centuries earlier, did not predetermine the later Ghurid breakthrough.
- C. Incorrect. Rajput victories at Gujarat (1178-79) and Tarain I (1191) disprove any claim of universal inferiority.
- D. Correct. This is the balanced, evidence-based verdict the topic builds toward: structural probability realised through contingent choice.

Trap: choosing between "predetermined" and "unrelated" instead of the required probabilistic, contingency-aware synthesis.

Remediation note: Remediation for this topic's predictable errors (the "Sind founded the Sultanate" trap, the "Persianate = ethnicity" trap, the "iqta = hereditary ownership" trap, the "Rajputs had no resources" trap, the "cavalry alone" trap, the "mosque = sovereignty" trap, the "open gate" trap and the "digitisation = verification" trap) is integrated directly into the option-by-option explanations and trap lines of Workbook MCQs 01-32 above (see, respectively, MCQs 03/24, 04/10, 08/13, 07/14/18, 16/20, 02/17, 06/11/29 and 26/27). No separate remedial MCQ bank is maintained.

Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Medieval Topic 01

Drill	Prompt	Minimum answer route	Fatal trap
A	What does "eve of medieval" mean?	periodization -> regional map -> continuity/change	Hindu/Muslim or one-date rupture
B	Distinguish Arab contacts.	merchant/settler/envoy/raider/state -> sea route -> political effect	all contact equals conquest
C	Assess Sindh.	711-12 campaign -> administration/accommodation -> limited reach -> consequence	nationwide conquest or insignificance
D	Use Chachnama critically.	early-13th-century Persian genre -> claimed lost Arabic source -> corroboration	eyewitness transcript
E	Separate Ghaznavid processes.	Shahi/Punjab incorporation -> raids/Somnath -> mixed motives -> Al-Biruni	one religious motive
F	Trace Ghurid transition.	Gujarat defeat -> Tarain I/II -> Chandawar -> Aibak/east boundary	inevitable one-battle conquest
G	Explain military outcomes.	cavalry/tactics/logistics/finance/frontier/rivalries -> counter-evidence	technology or national disunity alone
H	Control terminology.	Arab/Turk/Afghan/Persianate/Islamic/Ghaznavid/Ghurid	ethnic-religious conflation

PYQ status: all seven retained questions are application items; Topic 01 has zero direct routed PYQs.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

I.1 Audit method

```
MAINS: read official GS-I papers, 2018-2025.
Search concepts:
Arab contact . Sind . Malabar . Turkish conquest . Ghazni . Hindu Shahi
Rajput political order . Persianisation . frontier . outer bastions . iqta

PRELIMS: inspect available GS-I papers, 2018-2026.
Retain only:
1. directly owned questions; or
2. application questions requiring this topic's chronology or institutions.

CLASSIFY:
OWNED       = this topic is the question's central subject.
APPLICATION = another topic owns it, but this topic materially improves the answer.
INFERRED    = relevant question solved from source-grounded subject knowledge because
              the official same-series key is unavailable; never represented as official.
```

I.2 Directly owned Mains result

FACT: **COUNT: ZERO** No GS-I Mains question from 2018-2025 directly asks the pre-Sultanate political setting, Indo-Arab maritime contact, Hindu Shahi frontier, Persianisation of Turkish elites or the causes of the initial Turkish breakthrough as its central subject. ANALYSIS: This is consistent with the official syllabus boundary: Medieval History is directly owned by Prelims, while Mains GS-I uses it chiefly through art, literature and architecture. The topic remains important because it supplies context for source, technology and culture questions.

I.3 Directly owned Prelims result

FACT: **COUNT: ZERO with a locally readable official same-series key** Several adjacent questions test chronology, iqta or early-medieval dynasties, but their true ownership lies in later administration or regional-kingdom topics. They are solved below as application items rather than force-fitted. Because their official same-series keys are unavailable locally, every answer is explicitly marked as inferred.

I.4 Solved Prelims application PYQs - inferred answers

P-1 · Prelims 2019 · revenue administration of the Delhi Sultanate

FACT: **Question:** Consider the following statements:

1. The in-charge of revenue collection was known as *amil*.
2. The iqta system was an ancient indigenous institution.
3. The office of *Mir Bakshi* came into existence under the Khaljis.

(a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only (c) 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Sultanate administration, Topic 07. ANALYSIS: **Why relevant:** it tests the defining trap "iqta = indigenous/hereditary property".

ANALYSIS: **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (a) 1 only · Confidence: High**

Elimination logic

- FACT: Statement 1 is correct: *amil* was associated with revenue assessment/collection at the local level under the Sultanate.
- WRONG: Statement 2 is incorrect: iqta was part of the wider Islamic-West/Central Asian revenue-service tradition, not an ancient indigenous institution.
- WRONG: Statement 3 is incorrect: *Mir Bakshi* is principally a Mughal central office, not an office created by the Khalji sultans.

CAUTION: **Provenance note:** the attempted official UPSC key URL returned an error page. The answer is therefore an expert historical inference, not an official-key claim.

P-2 · Prelims 2020 · chronology of Pallava, Pala, Pratihara and Chola power

FACT: **Question:** Consider the following events in the history of India:

1. Rise of the Pratiharas under Bhoja.
2. Establishment of Pallava power under Mahendravarman I.
3. Establishment of Chola power under Parantaka I.
4. Foundation of the Pala dynasty by Gopala.

(a) 2-1-4-3 (b) 3-1-4-2 (c) 2-4-1-3 (d) 3-4-1-2

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Ancient/Early Medieval regional chronology. ANALYSIS: **Why relevant:** it establishes the political order preceding Topic 01.

ANALYSIS: **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (c) 2-4-1-3 · Confidence: High**

Chronology

1. Mahendravarman I's Pallava power - early seventh century.
2. Gopala founds the Pala dynasty - mid-eighth century.
3. Bhoja's Pratihara ascendancy - ninth century.
4. Parantaka I's Chola reign - early tenth century.

CAUTION: **Provenance note:** the local official-key link was unreadable. The sequence is inferred from established dynastic chronology and externally cross-checked, but is not labelled official.

P-3 · Prelims 2022 · early-medieval kings and dynasties

FACT: **Question:** Consider the following pairs:

1. Nannuka - Chandela
2. Jayashakti - Paramara
3. Nagabhata II - Gurjara-Pratihara
4. Bhoja - Rashtrakuta

(a) Only one pair (b) Only two pairs (c) Only three pairs (d) All four pairs

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Regional kingdoms, Topic 08. ANALYSIS: **Why relevant:** Chandellas and Pratiharas form part of the transition map.

> ANALYSIS: **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (b) Only two pairs · Confidence: High**

Pair-by-pair test

- FACT: Nannuka - Chandela: correct.
- WRONG: Jayashakti - Paramara: incorrect; Jayashakti belonged to the Chandela line.
- FACT: Nagabhata II - Gurjara-Pratihara: correct.
- WRONG: Bhoja - Rashtrakuta: incorrect in the intended pairing; Bhoja is associated with the Paramaras, while Mihira Bhoja belongs to the Gurjara-Pratiharas.

CAUTION: **Provenance note:** the attempted official key returned an error page. The answer is inferred from standard dynastic identification.

P-4 · Prelims 2023 · Hoysala, Gahadavala, Kakatiya and Yadava chronology

FACT: **Question:** Consider the following dynasties:

1. Hoysala
2. Gahadavala
3. Kakatiya
4. Yadava

How many of the above dynasties established their kingdoms in the early eighth century CE?

(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) Only three (d) None

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Regional kingdoms, Topic 08. ANALYSIS: **Why relevant:** the Gahadavalas are a major "eve of conquest" power.

> ANALYSIS: **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (d) None · Confidence: High**

Elimination logic

- Hoysalas emerged substantially later than the early eighth century.
- Gahadavalas rose in the late eleventh century.
- Kakatiya power belongs to a later early-medieval/medieval phase.
- Seuna Yadava political prominence also belongs to a later phase.

CAUTION: **Provenance note:** no locally held official 2023 key was available. The answer is inferred from established chronology.

ANALYSIS: **Audit conclusion:** all four application PYQs are now solved rather than omitted. Their answers are high-confidence historical inferences and are visually separated from official-key verification. This preserves usefulness without misrepresenting provenance.

M-1 · 2018 · GS-I · 10 marks · 150 words

FACT: **Question:** "Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India."

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Historical sources. ANALYSIS: **Topic 01 contribution:** Arab maritime circuits, outsider evidence and reconstruction of contact.

Demand decoding

- **Assess** requires a graded judgement, not a list of travellers.
- **Importance** requires comparison with other evidence.
- **Reconstruction** requires source criticism: what can the account establish, and what can it not?

Model answer

> Chinese and Arab accounts are high-value external witnesses when tied to named contexts. **Xuanzang's seventh-century record** describes Harsha's political world, Nalanda and Buddhist geography; it reconstructs institutions and routes, although a pilgrim naturally magnified Buddhist centres. **Sulaiman and al-Masudi** noticed major north Indian and Deccan powers and commerce linking Indian ports to the Persian Gulf; this proves wide trade and political reputations, but some information came through merchants rather than direct travel. **Al-Biruni's Kitab-ul-Hind*** used Sanskrit learning to compare religion, astronomy and social classification; it is unusually analytical, yet its Brahmanical textual access and north-western setting narrowed its social range. Their itinerary, genre, language and audience must therefore be tested against inscriptions, coins, archaeology and Indian texts. They are indispensable corroborative evidence, not neutral photographs of all-India conditions.

Why this earns marks: It assesses rather than lists, integrates three named sources with what each proves and limits, and ends with a graded corroboration-based judgement suited to 10 marks.

What a top answer must contain

1. Source class, not traveller biography.
2. Arab accounts linked to maritime commerce.
3. At least three filters: itinerary, language, purpose, patron/audience.
4. Co-relation with material and Indian textual evidence.
5. A graded final judgement.

Executable answer plan: Open with a one-line thesis that these accounts are high-value external witnesses only when checked against genre and corroboration; take Xuanzang, Sulaiman/al-Masudi and Al-Biruni as three claim -> evidence -> limit units in that order; close with the graded corroboration verdict already given.

How to improve this answer: Add one further named traveller or an inscriptional/numismatic cross-check (for example Rashtrakuta-grant evidence for Arab settlement) to show corroboration beyond the three travellers already used.

M-2 · 2020 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words

FACT: **Question:** "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment."

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Medieval literature and society. ANALYSIS: **Topic 01 contribution:** formation of the Persianate political-cultural sphere.

Demand decoding

"Comment" requires explanation plus qualification. "Spirit of the age" cannot be accepted as meaning the experience of every social group.

Model answer

> Persian sources reflect the age because their different genres preserve both the ideals and tensions of medieval society. **Barani's Tarikh-i Firoz Shahi** *chronicles Sultanate politics and measures such as Alauddin Khalji's market regulations, while his normative* **Fatawa-i Jahandari** exposes aristocratic, orthodox and hierarchical ideals; together they reveal statecraft, but Barani's elite prejudice and didactic purpose require caution. **Abul Fazl's court-sponsored Akbarnama** *legitimises Akbar's sovereignty, whereas the* **Ain-i Akbari** systematises offices, revenue and imperial resources; they demonstrate bureaucratic ambition, but imperial patronage encourages an idealised image. Counter-voices broaden this picture. **Badauni's Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh** *records conservative opposition to Akbar's religious experiments, proving dissent within the court, though its hostility is also polemical.* **Amir Khusrau's Khaza'in-ul-Futuh (ornate prose panegyric) and Tughluq-nama (narrative verse)** *celebrate conquest and Indo-Persian encounter; court dependence and poetic licence limit literal use.* **Gulbadan Begum's Humayun-nama**, a royal memoir commissioned under Akbar, reveals kinship, mobility and women's agency inside the Mughal household, but remains an elite-harem view. **The Fawa'id-ul-Fu'ad***, Amir Hasan Sijzi's record of Nizamuddin Auliya's discourses, shifts attention to the khanqah, urban anxieties and a wider devotional public; as disciple-compiled conversations rather than court history, it too is mediated. Thus Persian literature captures court, administration, dissent, domestic life and Sufi sociability-not the whole society. Its "spirit" becomes historically representative only through comparison across genres and corroboration with vernacular texts, inscriptions, coins, architecture and material evidence.

Why this earns marks: It comments through six genre-specific source clusters, links patronage and social reach to evidentiary limits, and gives a qualified verdict within a 15-mark scale.

What a top answer must contain

- Persianate ≠ ethnically Persian.
- Multiple genres and functions.
- Transregional and Indian adaptation.
- Patronage and elite bias.
- Co-relation and a qualified verdict.

Executable answer plan: Sequence the six named genres (Barani's chronicle and *Fatawa-i Jahandari*, Abul Fazl's *Akbarnama*/*Ain-i Akbari*, Badauni, Amir Khusrau, Gulbadan Begum, the *Fawa'id-ul-Fu'ad*) as claim -> evidence -> limit units, grouped by function (statecraft, dissent, domestic life, Sufi sociability), before the closing corroboration verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add a vernacular or inscriptional cross-check (for example a bhakti or regional-language source) to test whether the "spirit of the age" claim holds outside Persian elite circles.

M-3 · 2023 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words

FACT: **Question:** "What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society?"

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Sultanate administration, economy and society. ANALYSIS: **Topic 01 contribution:** cavalry, transregional circulation and institution-mediated adaptation.

Demand decoding

The question has two equal halves: identify changes and explain social influence. A device-list without mechanisms answers only half.

Model answer

The Sultanate accelerated the diffusion and recombination of technologies; it did not introduce every device to India for the first time. **The spinning wheel**, whose earliest Indian reference Satish Chandra places in the mid-fourteenth century, raised a spinner's efficiency several-fold; it enlarged yarn supply and textile markets, although spinning remained dispersed, gendered household labour. **Paper-making**, for which Indian manuscript evidence becomes available from the Sultanate centuries, made records and books cheaper to reproduce; it strengthened scribal administration and scholarship, but literacy remained socially restricted. **The Persian wheel and improved water-lifting devices** could extend irrigation and cultivation; they supported surplus where wells, capital and local control permitted, not uniformly across India. **Lime mortar with the true arch and dome**, visible in the scientifically constructed arches and dome of the Alai Darwaza, enabled larger durable structures; Indian masons adapted these forms, proving synthesis rather than the displacement of local craftsmanship. **Cavalry equipment, imported horses and road-post relays** increased military mobility and communication; they linked ports, frontier routes, treasury and army, but imposed high fiscal and import costs. The social influence was therefore institutional: courts purchased horses and commissioned buildings, revenue systems funded communications, and markets sustained paper-makers, weavers and masons. Technologies created new skills, urban demand and administrative reach, yet their benefits and burdens varied by region and class. The Sultanate's major contribution was accelerated circulation and Indian adaptation-neither total rupture nor unchanged continuity.

Why this earns marks: It answers both halves through five named technologies, explains a social mechanism and qualification for each, and avoids the inaccurate "first introduced" claim.

What a top answer must contain

- No "all technologies were first introduced" overclaim.
- Military, production, documentary and architectural categories.
- A mechanism for every social effect.
- Indian adaptation and artisan agency.
- Uneven consequences and balanced judgement.

Executable answer plan: Treat the five named technologies (spinning wheel, paper-making, Persian wheel, arch-and-dome, cavalry/road-post relays) as claim -> mechanism -> social effect -> qualification units, holding the two-halves structure (change, then influence) throughout.

How to improve this answer: Add a dated artefact or monument (for example a specific inscribed structure) to anchor the arch-and-dome claim beyond the Alai Darwaza reference already used.

O-1 (10 marks · 150 words)

Explain why the expression "India on the eve of the medieval age" should not be equated with a political vacuum.

Demand

Define the expression, establish existing capacity, identify change and conclude with a qualified transition.

Model answer

"On the eve" is an analytical snapshot of transition, not evidence that political institutions had vanished. The weakening of the **Pala-Pratihara-Rashtrakuta competitive order** redistributed power to **Gahadavalas, Chauhans, Paramaras, Chalukyas, Chandellas and Tomars**; their forts, agrarian revenue and armies prove regional state capacity, although authority was divided among sovereign centres. **Chola administration and maritime commerce in the south** further disprove an all-India vacuum, while also showing that north Indian fragmentation was regionally specific. The problem was collective rather than individual capacity. **The Chaulukya defeat of Muizzuddin in 1178-79 and Prithviraj's victory at Tarain in 1191** show that Indian powers could resist, but rival interests made durable common command difficult. At the same time, Hindu Shahi losses and a Punjab base moved organised Turkish states closer to the plains. The eve of the medieval transition was therefore a regionalised political order under altered frontier pressure. "Vacuum" conceals both strong successor states and the coordination problem that shaped their response.

Why this earns marks: It uses three evidence clusters to prove continuing capacity, identifies the precise weakness, and gives a qualified 10-mark verdict instead of narrating decline.

Top-answer checklist

- Regionalisation, not vacuum.
- Named states.
- Capacity versus coordination.
- Frontier transformation.
- Qualified judgement.

Executable answer plan: Use the three evidence clusters already built (regional successor states' capacity, the Chola counter-example, and the Gujarat 1178-79/Tarain 1191 resistance) as claim -> evidence -> qualification units, closing with the "regionalised order, not vacuum" verdict.

How to improve this answer: Name one additional regional dynasty's specific institutional feature (for example a Chandella fort or a Paramara grant) to deepen the "named states" evidence cluster.

O-3 (10 marks · 150 words)

What is meant by the Persianisation of Turkish elites, and why is it important for medieval Indian history?

Demand decoding

"What is meant by" requires a precise definition before any narrative; "why is it important" requires at least one institutional consequence, not a restatement of the definition.

Model answer

> Persianisation was the adoption of Persian language, literature, court etiquette and administrative practice by Turkish military elites; it did not imply Persian ethnicity or abandonment of Islam. **Turkish commanders recruited in the Iranian-Transoxianan world after Abbasid fragmentation assimilated the dominant Iranian language and culture**; this proves that entrants into India already possessed a transregional political idiom, though their societies remained culturally mixed. Its importance was institutional. **Ghazni** joined cavalry command to a Persianate court and documentary kingship, showing that Turkish power was more than weaponry, although its early Indian reach was often raid- and tribute-based. **Iqta**, a revocable revenue-service assignment, helped sultans sustain mobile troops without granting hereditary landownership; it linked administration to military capacity, but evolved further under the Delhi Sultanate. Persianisation therefore supplied language, legitimacy and governing techniques that later interacted with Indian revenue systems, elites and artisans. Medieval transition was institutional recombination, not a simple clash of ethnic civilisations.

Why this earns marks: It defines the term, uses three named examples to show political consequences and limits, and directly explains significance in a 10-mark frame.

Executable answer plan: Define Persianisation in one sentence, then use the two named evidence units already present (Ghazni's Persianate court/documentary kingship, and the iqta revenue-service assignment) as claim -> evidence -> qualification, closing with the "institutional recombination, not ethnic clash" verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add a specific named ruler or court title (for example Sabuktigin) to strengthen the "transregional political idiom" evidence beyond the general Ghazni reference.

O-5 (15 marks · 250 words)

"The Rajput political order combined considerable strength with a severe coordination problem." Discuss.

Demand decoding

"Discuss" requires both sides of the quoted claim - strength and the coordination problem - not only one; a one-sided answer fails the directive.

Model answer

The Rajput order combined substantial regional state capacity with weak collective strategy. **Gahadavalas, Chauhans, Paramaras, Chalukyas, Chandellas and Tomars** commanded agrarian revenue, forts, feudatories and military followings; their number proves regionalisation, not political vacuum, although resources were divided among sovereign centres. **The Chaulukya defeat of Muizzuddin near Mount Abu in 1178-79** and **Prithviraj's victory at the First Battle of Tarain in 1191** demonstrate effective resistance; neither courage nor battlefield capacity was absent. The central limitation was converting aggregate strength into durable common command. **Prithviraj's campaigns against neighbouring powers**, as Satish Chandra notes, left him politically isolated; regional ambition weakened diplomatic depth even when armies were large. **Gahadavala non-assistance during the struggle for the upper doab** further illustrates separate threat perceptions, though it should not be reduced to a timeless "Rajput disunity" stereotype. Feudatory contingents could mobilise locally but complicated unified reserves, intelligence and reinforcement. Rajput polities also adapted: coalitions formed, forts resisted and Turkish forces suffered reverses. Their problem was relational-opponents operating from Ghazni and Punjab could sometimes concentrate mobile forces and fiscal resources faster. The order was therefore strong in regional legitimacy and defence but limited in sustained inter-state coordination. Turkish victory reflected particular strategic asymmetries, not civilisational or moral inferiority.

Why this earns marks: It balances capacity and coordination through five named examples, rejects the bravery stereotype, and delivers an assessed rather than one-sided verdict.

Executable answer plan: Present the named-dynasty capacity evidence and the two 1178-79/1191 victories first (proving strength), then the Prithviraj-isolation and Gahadavala non-assistance evidence (proving the coordination problem), closing with the "strong in legitimacy, limited in coordination" verdict already given.

How to improve this answer: Add one further named feudatory or alliance episode to strengthen the coordination-problem half without weakening the capacity half.

O-7 (15 marks · 250 words)

Explain how cavalry mobility, revenue organisation and command interacted in the Turkish military advantage.

Demand decoding

"Explain how ... interacted" requires a mechanism linking all three named factors, not three separate lists; a paragraph that treats them independently misses the directive.

Model answer

Cavalry superiority was an organisational system, not a racial or weapon-based attribute. **Ghaznavid roads linking Ghazni with Kabul and Jalalabad**, followed by a Punjab base, reduced operational friction; they enabled remounts, supply, intelligence and retreat, although difficult terrain still constrained campaigns. **At the Second Battle of Tarain, light mounted archers harassed Prithviraj's slower-moving force from several directions**; this proves manoeuvre and coordinated wings mattered, but the earlier Rajput victory in 1191 shows cavalry did not predetermine outcomes. Revenue made mobility sustainable. **Iqta gave an assignee the right to collect state revenue in return for maintaining troops, without hereditary ownership over land or cultivators**; it converted surplus into deployable force, although its mature Delhi Sultanate form evolved after the initial breakthrough. **Horse-import circuits through western ports and Central Asian routes** supported mounted warfare but also made it costly and dependent on trade. Command integrated these assets. **Prithviraj's politically isolated coalition and separate feudatory contingents** could possess large aggregate resources yet face delays in concentration and reinforcement. A Turkish ruler able to coordinate reserves, reconnaissance and pursuit could exploit that gap. Thus horses without finance were unsustainable, revenue without command remained dispersed, and command without roads lacked speed. The advantage arose from interaction among mobility, fiscal support and concentrated leadership, not cavalry technology alone.

Why this earns marks: It links five named examples into a mechanism, includes Tarain counter-evidence, and explains the interaction demanded rather than listing military features.

Executable answer plan: Use the three interacting evidence units already built (Ghaznavid roads/Punjab base, iqta-funded troops, and Tarain II mounted-archer tactics with Tarain I as counter-evidence) as claim -> evidence -> qualification, closing with the "horses without finance, revenue without command, command without roads" interaction verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add a specific horse-import route or price detail to make the "costly and dependent on trade" qualification more evidence-based.

O-8 (20 marks · 300-350 words)

The establishment of Turkish rule in north India was a structural possibility, not a historical inevitability. Critically examine.

Demand decoding

"Critically examine" requires testing the thesis against counter-evidence, not only illustrating it; both the enabling structures and the reverses (Gujarat 1178-79, the 1191/1192 reversal, the Anhilwara limit) must appear.

Model answer

> By the late tenth to twelfth centuries, structures increased the possibility of Turkish expansion without making it inevitable. **Abbasid fragmentation produced regional military states whose Turkish commanders were Islamised and Persianised**; this joined cavalry command to Iranian court and administrative practices, but these states also fought and lost against rivals. **Hindu Shahi losses around Kabul and Jalalabad** reduced north India's strategic depth, while **Ghaznavid roads and a Punjab base** lowered the cost of supply, intelligence and repeated operations. Institutions converted opportunity into force. **Iqta linked revocable revenue assignments to troop maintenance**, allowing rulers to concentrate resources without conceding hereditary landownership; its exact Indian form, however, developed over time. North India was not a vacuum: **Gahadavalas, Chauhans, Chalukyas and Chandellas** possessed forts, agrarian revenue and armies. Their limitation was that separate strategic interests and feudatory command made collective reinforcement less reliable. Counter-evidence disproves inevitability. **The Chaulukyas defeated Muizzuddin near Mount Abu in 1178-79**, forcing him to shift his approach towards Punjab. **Prithviraj defeated him at the First Battle of Tarain in 1191**; the reversal in 1192 therefore reflects learning, preparation and tactical choice, not a predetermined civilisational outcome. Even after battlefield success, Turkish power could not retain distant **Anhilwara**, showing that bases and garrisons still bounded expansion. **Hasan Nizami's narrative and coins bearing Prithviraj's name with "Sri Muhammad Sam"** indicate an initial attempt to govern Ajmer through subordinate local authority; this proves conquest still required accommodation, although the sequence is source-dependent. Plunder and the **ghazi** idiom aided mobilisation, but neither explains variation in outcomes. Nor can horse technology explain success without roads, finance and command. Turkish rule was a **structural possibility** created by altered frontier depth, military-fiscal concentration and regional rivalry; it became reality through contingent leadership, diplomacy and battlefield adaptation. Structures changed the odds, while actors decided how those odds were realised.

Why this earns marks: It critically integrates eight named examples, tests the thesis with reverses and post-conquest limits, and produces a reasoned probability-not-inevitability verdict.

Executable answer plan: Sequence the eight named evidence units already built - Abbasid fragmentation, Hindu Shahi losses, Ghaznavid roads/Punjab base, iqta, named Rajput states, the 1178-79 and 1191 reverses, the 1192 reversal, and the Hasan Nizami/coin evidence - as claim -> evidence -> qualification, closing with the existing "structural possibility, not inevitability" verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one further named regional ruler's post-1192 resistance episode to extend the "durable sovereignty still required accommodation" qualification.

O-10 (20 marks · 300-350 words)

"Organisation, not weapons; coordination, not courage; probability, not inevitability." Use this proposition to explain the Turkish breakthrough in north India.

Demand decoding

The quoted proposition has three paired clauses; the answer must address all three (organisation vs weapons, coordination vs courage, probability vs inevitability) rather than collapsing them into one general narrative.

Model answer

> The proposition corrects three monocausal explanations of the Turkish breakthrough. **Organisation, not weapons: At the Second Battle of Tarain, light mounted archers harassed Prithviraj's slower force from several directions**; this proves manoeuvre, reserves and command mattered more than horses alone. **Ghazni-Kabul-Jalalabad roads and a Punjab base** sustained supply, intelligence and retreat, while **iqta revenue-service assignments** converted surplus into maintained troops. Yet Muizzuddin's **1178-79 defeat in Gujarat** shows that the same broad military culture could fail without favourable strategy and logistics. **Coordination, not courage: The Chaulukya victory and Prithviraj's First Tarain victory in 1191** demonstrate Rajput fighting capacity. The weakness was pooling multiple sovereign resources. **Prithviraj's expansion had isolated him politically**, and separate feudatory commands complicated reserves and reinforcement. This was not permanent incapacity-coalitions did form-but concentrated Turkish command could exploit delays in particular campaigns. **Probability, not inevitability: Hindu Shahi losses around Kabul and Jalalabad** reduced strategic depth and raised the probability of repeated penetration. Nevertheless, the reversal between Tarain 1191 and 1192 proves that preparation, leadership and tactical adaptation altered outcomes. Turkish inability to retain distant **Anhilwara** further shows that victory did not erase logistical limits. Durable sovereignty still required garrisons, revenue and accommodation with local elites. **Hasan Nizami's account and the "Sri Muhammad Sam" coins issued with Prithviraj's name** suggest that Ajmer was first managed through subordinate local rule; this proves political consolidation required accommodation after battle, although textual and numismatic evidence must be read together. Likewise, the **ghazi** language could legitimise mobilisation, but it cannot explain why Muslim Turkish states also lost to non-Muslim opponents or why campaigns succeeded unevenly. Religion, plunder, geography and technology contributed, but none independently explains changing results. The strongest chain is **condition**-frontier change and regional rivalry; **mechanism**-mobility, finance and unified command; and **trigger**-diplomacy, leadership and battlefield choice. The breakthrough was a contingent organisational success, not proof of civilisational superiority or foreordained collapse.

Why this earns marks: It structures the response around the quotation, integrates eight named evidence points and counter-cases, and ends with a causal rather than moral explanation.

Cross-cutting answer-writing protocol (applies across all six original models)

1. Define the process before narrating events.
2. Separate chronology from causation.
3. Name actors precisely: Arab merchant, Turkish commander, Persianate court, Rajput polity.
4. Use geography through mechanisms: route, base, supply and intelligence.
5. Distinguish aggregate resources from concentrated resources.
6. Avoid bravery, race and civilisation stereotypes.
7. For technology, explain institution and social effect.
8. Include evidence against your own thesis.
9. Use "enabled", "increased probability" and "mediated", not "automatically caused".
10. End with a comparative, graded judgement.

Executable answer plan: Address each of the three paired clauses in turn as its own claim -> evidence -> qualification unit (Tarain II tactics/iqta/roads; Gujarat-Tarain I victories/Prithviraj isolation; Hindu Shahi losses/1191-92 reversal/Anhilwara limit), then close with the "contingent organisational success" verdict already given.

How to improve this answer: Add a specific counter-example of a Turkish defeat by a non-Muslim opponent elsewhere to sharpen the existing point that the ghazi idiom cannot explain uneven campaign outcomes.